Usage and Attitude Study

A **Usage and Attitude (U&A) study** (sometimes also described as an Attitude and Usage, or A&U study), is a popular survey-based study used in market research to gain a deeper understanding of how consumers use your product or service and what are their attitudes toward it. It helps you to understand your market at a deep level, understand who is buying what, from where and how often, and to explore the relationship between opinions/attitudes and consumption habits.

Some of the important questions for any marketing professional are –

- What exactly is my product or brand used for?
- Do different types of customers use my product or brand in different ways?
- Are there different patterns of typical usage for my product?
- Do certain segments of consumers use my product more or less often?
- Do customers use my product alone, or do they use competitor products, and which ones? Or do the customers use my product/service with other tools? If so, which ones?

U&A studies are typically done in a very customised way and, depending on the business objectives, generally include some or all of the following:

1. **Market sizing** (e.g. category penetration, usage frequency, etc.). Understanding the penetration of various product categories into the market, as well as usage or consumption frequency. For example, even if you sell a broad range of clothing in your online shop, it might be the case that online shoppers prefer to buy certain product categories (like underwear) in a physical store, where they can try items on or get a better sense of how the fabric feels. Knowledge like this can help you with all sorts of marketing decisions, like what to stock, and what to promote, and to whom.

2. **General category understanding** (e.g. who uses, what/when/where /how, category dissatisfactions, etc.). Learn more about the characteristics of the market as a whole. For instance, if you sell clothing online, you might want to learn more about the characteristics of the typical online fashion shopper, when they tend to shop, how often, and how (e.g., via mobile, tablet or laptop).

3. **Understanding brands** (brand penetration, brand perceptions, brand choice drivers, etc.). You can employ usage and attitude research to gain insight into things like brand penetration, brand perceptions, brand equity, and brand choice drivers - vital in developing your competitive strategy.

4. **Information for targeting** (e.g. attitudinal or behavioural segmentations). A usage and attitude study can also be used to derive crucial information that can be used to support customer segmentation on the basis of attitudes and behaviours, helping you with your targeting and messaging efforts.

To put in terms of market, a U&A study helps in understanding the 3 key aspects –

- **Category analysis:** products purchased, frequency of purchase and consumption patterns, purchase motivations and barriers, consumption occasions, formats, place of purchase, and for whom they buy.
- **Brand health**: brand awareness (spontaneous and suggested), brands purchased (last x months and most frequently), brand image and brand loyalty.
- **Consumer analysis:** consumer and buyer profile and consumer segmentation.

When to perform a U&A study

One of the major benefits of a usage and attitude study is that it is so versatile and can be used in a variety of different applications. Specifically, you should consider performing a U&A study if you have one of the following needs:

- You feel the need to better understand customers' desires and pain points
- You think you might be missing out on opportunities to drive additional consumption or usage
- You are on the verge of developing new product categories or marketing strategies
- You want to develop a stronger understanding of the broader competitive landscape

Objectives of a Usage and Attitude study

Observe the latest trends in buyer behaviour that drive market dynamics in your industry

Buyers are constantly changing the way they think about products and services – with implications for their buying behaviour. Their attitudes and usage changes are shaped by not only how you interact with them (for instance, through your marketing campaigns), but also the actions of your competitors and broader shifts in the market environment. The Covid-19 pandemic is a great example: producers of alcoholic drinks found, for instance, that not only did sales of wine and spirits to consume at home increase, but that average spend per consumer was also on the up. When consumption patterns shift like this, or the industry suffers some kind of shock or disruption, it is time to take stock of consumer usage and attitudes, to better inform your next steps.

Gain a deeper understanding of your buyers and their behaviour to drive adoption and purchases of your products or services

Once the customer takes your product home, the sale is over, right? Well, not quite.
Sometimes, by focusing on the supply side of business – driving the sale – we forget to consider exactly how our products fit into our customers daily lives once they take it away from the store. But, understanding customer usage at a deeper level can help make sure that your product is a great fit for the customer, and that additional needs are met, which in turn, can drive future sales. For instance, let us say your main product is an at home elliptical machine. Taking time to learn about customer interactions with it, like which room they keep it in, how often they work out on it, and how family members take turns to use it can provide deep insight that you can inform future product development and help you better focus your marketing campaigns. You might find, for example, that younger family members want to use the machine, but that the size is not child-friendly, prompting the development of training equipment specifically for kids.

Measure demand for your products to refine your offerings at each step of the development process: ideation, development, go-to-market, and iteration

Another objective of U&A studies is to measure consumer demand for your products among a target audience – helping you to refine your positioning and product offerings, and putting you in the best possible position to drive sales. For instance, imagine you are a seller of yoga mats, but you want to expand your market to reach beginners. Based on the results of a U&A study that evaluates overall demand for yoga, as well as where yoga mats are used (e.g. in the home, or taken to a studio) and how (the types of stretches performed), you might be able to develop an illustrated mat that shows beginners where to place their feet for certain, popular poses – in other words, creating an innovative product that better meets the needs of your customers, and driving interest in your brand.

To inform future strategies

If you are preparing for a significant change, like launching a new product range, investing in a major advertising campaign, extending the brand, or entering a new market, a usage and attitude study is absolutely vital. It is impossible to feel confident about whether the leap will be a successful one unless you have deep, up-to-date knowledge about your customer base, their usage patterns, and their attitudes towards your brand and others. By administering a U&A study, you can get clarity around these questions, which will help you shape and optimize your strategies.

Overall, performing a U&A research study can help you identify opportunities to expand and grow your business through an optimized brand and product strategy.

How do you conduct a usage and attitude study? U&A study methodology

There are a few different ways that a usage and attitude study can be performed. However, one of the most effective ways follows the traditional sales conversion funnel model, starting with gaining a broader understanding of your market, and narrowing to focus your attention on the specific way they interact with, or perceive of your brand. Let us take a look at each step.

Step 1: Obtain the right sample

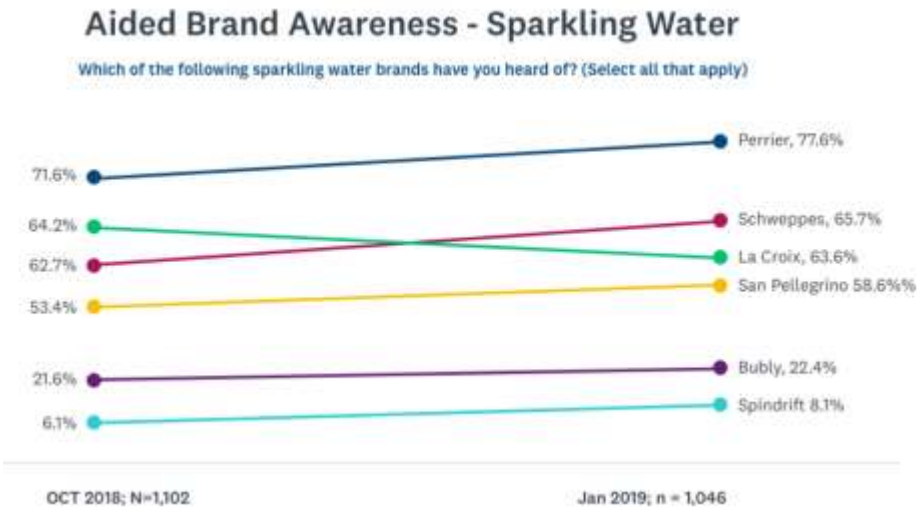
While the data from U&A studies can be immensely valuable, many firms attempting to use them fall at the first hurdle, by failing to obtain an appropriate sample. It is crucial that the sample from which you collect your data is genuinely representative of your customer base. If, for instance, your sample is skewed towards an older audience that prefers high street shopping to online shopping, your evaluation of the attitudes and behaviours of your market is unlikely to be valid. Instead, you will need to carefully calibrate your audience so that it reflects your customers in terms of demographics, psychographics and behaviours. The sample can be refined along lines like gender, income, employment, and more.

Step 2: Use unprompted recall to set a baseline

Just as a U&A study is often used to establish a baseline to inform future marketing decisions, the first part of a usage and attitude survey can help you set a reference point for further research. If you ask respondents to name the brands or products that instantly come to mind in a specified category, unprompted, you will get a solid idea of their awareness of your brand compared to competitors', as well as the effectiveness of any recent marketing campaigns.

Step 3: Move to assess attitudes and usage of specific brands

Next, use the survey to explore customer attitudes towards, and usage of specific products or brands. Prompted recall is an excellent way to do this. For example, you might list a series of competing brands and then ask respondents to indicate which they are aware of, which they currently use, and which they have considered using.



My methodology –

I create an awareness score for every brand. For this, I classify the responses for awareness into 3 groups:

- **Top-of-mind** – the first brand mentioned by the respondent without any aid or prompting
- **Unaided awareness** – the other brands mentioned without being aided by the interviewer
- **Aided awareness** – asking the respondent if they are aware of the brands not mentioned.

E.g. the question would be

What are the brands of mobile phones that you are aware of?

Samsung		Oppo		Nokia		Huawei	
Apple		Vivo		Motorola		IQOO	
Poco		Xiomi		ASUS		Lava	
OnePlus		Realme		Google		Micromax	

The first brand mentioned by the respondent will be marked as "TOM", short for Top of Mind.
Prompt the respondent, Any other?
Other brands mentioned by respondent without any assistance are marked "Unaided".

Then, prompt the respondent – Are you aware of brand ____?
Mark the brands for which the respondent has answered yes, as "Aided".

I then calculate the **awareness score for each brand**. For this, I combine the 3 questions by assigning a weightage. Sample weights can be: 3 to TOM, 2 to Unaided and 1 for Aided awareness.
Weights have been selected randomly.

Step 4: Dive into the detail

Once you have asked about brand knowledge and use, it is time to get a little deeper into customers' perceptions of your brand, and maybe even those of your competitors. For example, imagine you have launched a premium online clothing store. Do customers really perceive your brand as premium, or are there competing stores which are seen as even more prestigious? By asking about perceptions of your positioning, you can get a sense of how your brand is placed in the existing market, as well as its competitive strength.

So, when carrying out a study of uses and attitudes, it is important to define:

a) Specific objectives: Starting from the consumer behaviour analysis, it is necessary to define the specific objectives according to the purpose of the research. For example, if you want to carry out a study to identify new opportunities on special dates such as Mother's/ Father's Day, Valentine's Day, etc., it would be necessary to analyze not only the linkage of the category to these dates but also to identify behaviours about the percentage of celebration of each of the dates, as well as what consumers look for and value when including chocolate in these celebrations.

b) The market: What are the current market players, both at the category and brand level, always taking into account both direct and indirect competition at the category level, so it is necessary to keep in mind and consider including in the study the possible cannibalization of the category under investigation.

c) The target audience: Depending on the specific objective, such as new product launches, finding new market niches, etc., we propose a baseline study that includes both consumers and non-consumers. Including non-consumers allows us to know, on the one hand, the consumer motivations, i.e. what the consumer needs/ wants, and, on the other hand, the barriers to the category or brand, thus obtaining the consumer insights necessary to find new consumer levers.

d) The sample: For the sample, it is essential to have a minimum of n=400 cases to have a sufficient model for analysis. If a reading of results for a specific target (age, gender, area, consumer of brand x, etc.) is desired, it would be necessary to expand the sample, having a minimum of n=100 cases for the selected subgroup or sub-target. To ensure the desired sample of analysis by subgroups, it is necessary to establish quotas to obtain the proposed model.

f) The questionnaire: Once the above points have been defined, the next step is the development of the questionnaire. It is essential to be clear about the objectives so that, in the case of an initial baseline study, the development of the questionnaire would be carried out from scratch. Whereas, in the case of an updated study, i.e., repetition of a U&A to update the data, the questionnaire should be kept to make a comparison, thus having evolutionary data.
In the case of an initial baseline study, it is necessary to collect the information available from the brand to have a correct contextualization, both of the category and the brands to be included, as well as the image

attributes, motivations, etc., making sure to speak to the consumer in their language. In case of not enough information on the category, it would be necessary to carry out a previous exploratory study through qualitative research.

Usage and Attitude survey questions

Pain points, needs and desires

Whether you are selling an existing product or service to a known market, or developing a new product offering, it is crucial that you have in mind a profile of your target consumer. Administering a U&A survey to capture customer needs, desires and pain points, will help you understand, at a deeper level, who your customer is, what they want, and why. You can use either closed-ended or open-ended questions to capture this kind of insight *(of course, I favour ONLY closed ended questions)*. For example, you might ask questions like:

- What is the most frustrating thing about shopping for clothes online?
- What stops you from buying clothes online?
- If you had an unlimited budget, would you spend more on clothes online, or offline? [online/offline]
- When you buy clothes online, which of the following factors is the most important to you? [the price/ the fit/ the quality/ the ethics/ the brand]

Attitudes and usage of your brand or product

As the name might suggest, the questions in a U&A research survey should be designed to help you learn more about consumer attitudes and behaviour along the customer journey. That means focusing attention onto perception of the products, how customers feel about your offerings, and how they use your products in their day to day lives. For example, consider a question as simple as:

- How frequently do you shop online for new clothes?

The answers to this question alone can help you to segment your market on the basis of consumption behaviour. You might find that you have three markets: those that shop online infrequently, those that never shop online, and those that shop online every day. Analysing the answers in conjunction with the answers to questions about consumer experiences shopping online, or their attitudes to online shopping generally will give you deep insight that can help you ensure that the specific needs of each segment is met, and that new products or services are appropriately targeted to the right segments, and that your customers are satisfied, time after time.

Attitudes to your rivals

A U&A study is not just about assessing consumer attitudes to your own brand and product categories. Comparison questions can yield powerful insight into your positioning relative to your competitors. For example, you might present respondents with a list of competing products and brands, and ask them to rank them from their most preferred to their least preferred. Alternatively, you might ask specific questions about the relative attributes of different products in a single category, such as:

- Which of the following brands do you think is the best quality?
- Which of the following brands do you think is the most reliable?
- Which of the following brands do you think is the most ethical?

Buying and purchasing habits

Questions that capture shopping and purchasing behaviours are crucial to developing the appropriate promotional, placement and distribution strategies that we know drive sales. The types of questions that will be useful here include:

- Questions about the kinds of stores that your respondents visit
- Questions about the triggers that lead them to make purchases
- Question about any barriers to buying that they perceive
- Questions about their loyalty to you and any competitors

Product awareness questions

- How familiar are you with Product X?
- Which of these products are you familiar with?
- Which of the following brands do you think is the best quality?

- How did you hear about Product X?

Product usage questions
- Which of these products have you used?
- When was the last time you used Product X?
- How frequently do you use Product X?

Product satisfaction questions
- How do you rate your satisfaction with Product X?
- What would improve about Product X?
- Would you recommend Product X to a friend or family member?

Product purchasing habits questions
- How frequently do you shop for Product X?
- What stops you from buying Product X?
- Where do you purchase Product X?
- What causes you to purchase Product X?

Statement matrix questions *(respondents answer on a scale from strongly disagree to strongly agree)*
- I take advantage of special offers
- I like to compare the prices of different products
- I read reviews before purchasing a product
- I like to try new products
- I trust recommendations from friends and family more than branded content

Tips for creating a Usage and Attitude study

U&As are highly valuable in providing businesses with a foundational understanding of their market and customers. However, a poorly designed U&A survey can undermine the actionability of the results. Use the following tips to make sure your U&A survey provides you with insight that you can act upon:

- **Establish an objective for the survey.** You should have a clear understanding of how the data will be used once you have gathered it.
- **Create an interactive, engaging survey**. Sometimes, respondents find it difficult to recall or describe how they use products in their day to day lives. Use rich media like images of your product or a video of your service to bring the idea to life and stimulate valid, useful responses.

Don't try to cram in too much. Long, boring surveys that try to capture everything in one go rarely get you the results you need.

So, in summary, use a U&A research study to develop understanding about the appeal of your products and services to your customers and to identify future market opportunities by exploring customers' purchase, perception and usage patterns.

Downsides

Given the vast canvas that a U&A study attempts to study, the research can be plagued by a lack of actionability. Many U&A's suffer from one or more of the following issues:

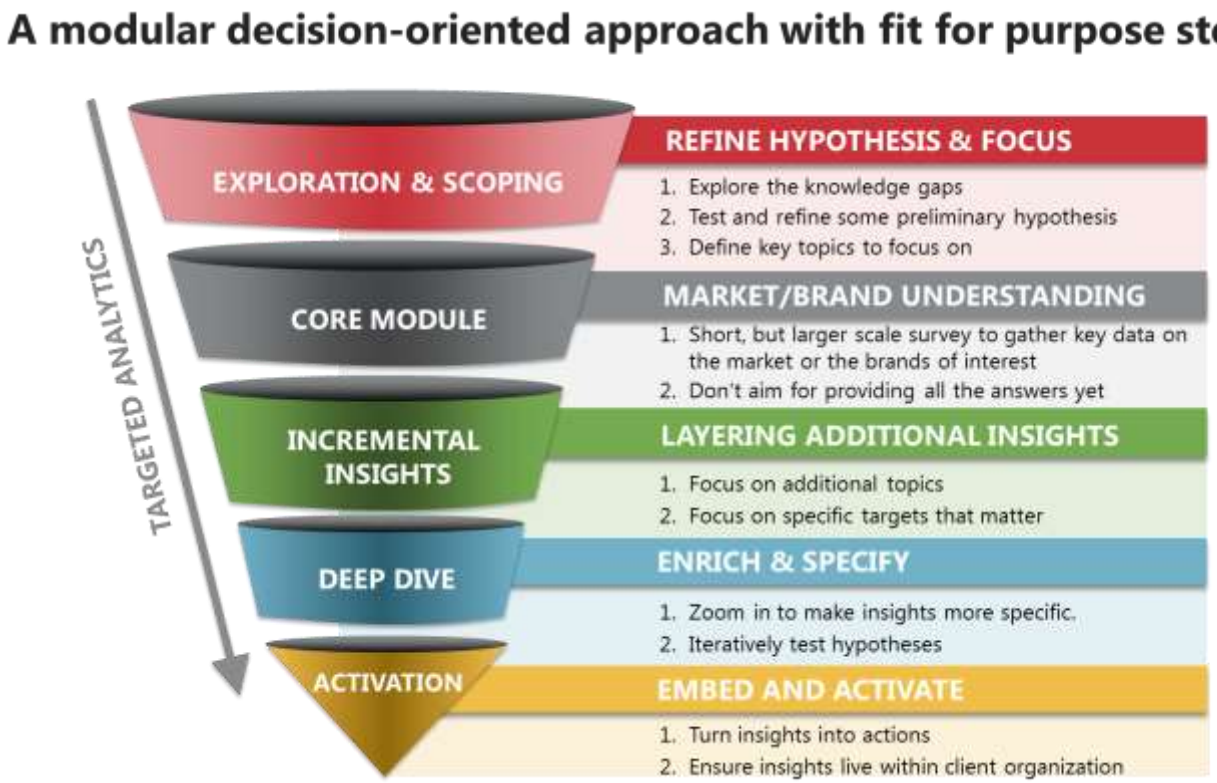
1. No precise definition of business objectives, i.e. no clear idea of how results of the U&A will be used once results are available.
2. Because of lack of precise business objectives, U&A's can become inflexible 'mega surveys' which are slow and do not allow for incremental learning.
3. Long non-engaging questionnaires which erode the validity of the answers. Data quality is a problem for surveys that go beyond the 25 minutes: satisficing responses increase, there is more cheating & skipping sections and respondents start perceiving it as too long. This is particularly problematic for categories with a large competitive set of products or services.
4. Most U&A's collect information via standard surveys only. In particular, when it comes to 'behaviours', this approach has its limitations in terms of what people can remember; some information can only be collected accurately when measured in the moment and/or via observation.

Recommendation

Understand the specific application of the results (i.e. new market opportunity, competitive understanding, drivers of usage for branding campaign, etc.). Hypotheses should drive the process step by step.
It uses a modular & flexible approach which allows for incremental decision making

Do not start with a big mega survey. Rather, use a modular and interactive approach. As such, insights come in incrementally and faster than with the traditional mega survey approach.

Step 1 – Exploration phase. Understanding what is already known and which information is really needed by the client. The defined Business Objective of the client is always the key guideline for this step, ideally delivered in a workshop format.
Step 2 – The key U&A questions will be tackled next. Typically, they are around the attitude of customers.
Follow-up steps – Focus on other areas where insights are required.



Benefits of Usage and Attitude Surveys

Create customer-centric products/services

Usage and attitude studies help companies understand the needs, wants, and expectations of their customers. Therefore, by understanding these motivations, businesses can better align their product or service offerings with customer preferences. As a result of creating products that are tailored to customer needs, wants and expectations, brands will likely see higher customer satisfaction and loyalty. For e.g., 70% of consumers may say that how well a company understands their individual needs impacts their loyalty.

Produce effective marketing and advertising campaigns

By measuring and identifying customer needs and preferences, companies can develop more effective marketing campaigns and increase brand awareness. Conducting usage and attitude studies will provide data that states who exactly is buying your product, how/when they use it, and how these interactions differ across demographics. As a result, companies can use this information to identify customer segments and target them with tailored marketing messages.

For example, say a bank conducts a U&A survey and the study reveals:

- Millennial women are 5X more likely to apply for new credit cards
- Millennial women discover new banking products the most on Google Search

With this insight, the bank can create paid search and display campaigns targeting millennial women with relevant keywords.

Measure customer loyalty and satisfaction

These studies can also be used to measure customer loyalty and satisfaction. For instance, companies can gain valuable insights into how likely customers are to use the product or service again. Additionally, you could measure and calculate net promoter scores in a usage and attitude study. It acts as another layer of quantifying brand loyalty. It includes asking respondents to rate how likely they are to recommend the product or service to a friend or family member. Based on the number of promoters, organizations can determine how loyal customers are to their brand. This data can be used to inform business development strategies and develop customer retention strategies.

Identify potential areas for improvement

Lastly, usage and attitude studies can help companies identify potential opportunities for growth and expansion. By collecting customer feedback, businesses can make changes to their products or services that will better meet people's needs and expectations. This can help businesses stay ahead of the competition and ensure customer satisfaction.

Examples of U&A studies

CASE 1. Brand image improvement

A leading brand in the FMCG market detected that consumer had lost connection with their brand. Faced with this situation, the company considered a change in the choice of brand ambassador, so they launched a Usage and Attitude study, Brand Health and Ad trackings, and several advertising Post-Tests. The data from the survey showed that one of the celebrities had a 90% affinity with the brand, but 75% of the audience was against the type of advertising used. Based on these results, a communication plan was drawn up to help bring the brand closer to consumers. This proximity resulted in a 20% increase in sales compared to the previous year.

CASE 2. New target repositioning

Faced with falling sales, a multinational dairy products company decided to reformulate its communication strategy and use an approach based on the support of its "healthy" brands to differentiate itself within the massified dairy products category.

To this end, the company conducted several U&A studies, Exploratory Phase, Concept Test, and Product Test, in order to identify the consumption habits of its target audience, as well as their relationship with its brand. Insights that led the brand to redefine its target, as well as the design and launch of two new pilot products. A redefinition that ended up giving the brand an increase of 4 points of penetration in the global market.

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